

D&D: BASIC

the mapper to follow, since the mapper need not translate feet to squares before drawing the map. Scale is very important when giving directions in terms of squares.

Whenever the characters are expected to know the shape of a dungeon, the DM should draw this outline before play begins. Even if the outline cannot be given to the players, the DM should still draw in a starting door, room, or corridor. The DM can also save mapping time by drawing in complex rooms for the mapper. However, this should only be done in extreme situations. Players should learn to become good mappers, and the only way they will learn is by doing it themselves.

MONSTER DESCRIPTIONS: When the characters first encounter monsters, the DM should describe what the monsters look like, instead of merely giving the name of the monsters. The players will eventually recognize monsters by their descriptions.

MONSTER HIT POINTS: The DM should *never* reveal the hit points of the monsters. It is enough to tell the players how a monster reacts after a successful attack. For example: "It's bleeding from a number of wounds and staggering a bit, but it's still fighting". The players should not know the level of an NPC until they have adventured with him or her.

SURPRISE: When monsters attack by surprise, the DM does not need to describe the monster. It is enough for the DM to describe the attack. For example: "From out of the dark shadows, Morgan Ironwolf suddenly feels a paw reach out and claw her leg. She takes 3 points of damage." Of course, the monster should be described after the surprise round is over. Continuing the above example: "You then see by your flickering torchlight that a huge bear-like creature with a head like a great bird is charging you!" If the party had seen an owlbear before, it could just be named; however, the mysterious appearance of an unknown monster is part of the thrill of the game.

MAGIC ITEMS: When describing magical treasure items, the DM should only do so in general terms. For example: "A ring" should be mentioned, not "a ring of invisibility". Characters must experiment to find out what an item does. Magical weapons and armor usually reveal their true natures after being used in combat.

DIVIDING MAGICAL TREASURE: While it is not the DM's job to divide treasure between the players, the DM may offer suggestions. Non-magical treasure is usually divided evenly among all surviving players. Magical treasures may be divided by the players' choice, or by having each player roll d%: the highest roll would get first pick of magical items, the second highest would get second pick, and so forth.

PLAYER ADVANCEMENT: If no one has reached the 2nd level of experience in three or four adventures, the DM should consider giving more treasure. If most of the players have reached the 3rd level of experience in this time, the DM should consider cutting down the amount of treasure, or increasing the "toughness" of the monsters.

GRUDGES: Occasionally, a grudge develops between characters. A small grudge can often make the game more interesting, particularly if the grudge develops because the players are playing their character roles well. For example, a Lawful character might have a grudge with a Chaotic character who slew a prisoner after the Lawful character gave his word that the prisoner would not be harmed. If any grudge gets out of hand, the DM should try to subtly warn the players. If a grudge develops to a point where it is ruining the adventure, the DM may have a powerful creature interfere. The DM may plan an encounter with a gold dragon who tells the players that, unless the grudge ends immediately, severe steps will be taken (at most, the deaths of the offending characters).

DM INSTRUCTIONS

MINIATURE FIGURES: D&D adventures are more interesting to play when figures are used. Metal miniatures (about 15 to 25 millimeters high) are often used, for they can be easily painted to look like real dungeon adventurers. Many excellent figures are designed specially for fantasy role playing games. These are available from TSR or from local hobby stores. If metal miniatures cost more than the players want to spend, many companies make inexpensive packs of plastic figures. These are not specifically made for fantasy role playing, but can easily be adapted for it. Inexpensive plastic monsters of many sizes are also available in local stores.

PLAYING SURFACE: Combats are easy to keep track of when large sheets of graph paper, covered with plexiglass or transparent adhesive plastic (contact paper), are used to put the figures on. The best sheets for this use have 1" squares, and the scale of 1" = 5' should be used when moving the figures. With water-based markers or grease pencils, an entire room or battle can be drawn in just a few seconds. When the battle is over, the board may be wiped off, leaving it ready for the next combat. Dominoes or plastic building blocks can also be used to outline walls and corridors. When using figures, the DM should make sure that a solid table top is used, so the figures won't fall over when the table is bumped.

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AFTERWORD

This concludes the D&D BASIC rules. While it was not possible to cover everything that might happen in a game, the ideas here give a solid framework to build on. And there is more to come! The D&D EXPERT SET expands the game, with lots of new monsters, spells, treasures, and information for character levels 4-14. The D&D COMPANION SUPPLEMENT adds even more, and explains characters to 36th level. To add to the games, TSR also publishes dungeon modules especially for use with DUNGEONS & DRAGONS® games. The "B" series of modules (including **B1: In Search of the Unknown** and **B2: The Keep on the Borderlands**) are an excellent source of ideas to build on or add to a campaign "world".

TSR is happy to answer questions about DUNGEONS & DRAGONS rules. When writing, leave room to put the answers with the questions, enclose a stamped self-addressed envelope, and send it to:

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